

This is not to say that this is the best way to build a big business or score a big financial success. We are only saying that is the best way for someone interested in building family wealth. Taking a flyer on an idea, such as setting up a Web-based business to make home deliveries of groceries or opening a chain of Internet cafes, may pay off. If it does, the entrepreneur gets rich and is celebrated as a hero in the financial press.

But the family wealth builder is not interested in becoming a media hero. He wants to be a family hero. And he will more likely succeed by not taking the risk of a big, expensive, flamboyant failure. He will play it safe. Test carefully. And never put the family fortune—even if it is tiny—at risk. He is not particularly interested in seeing *his* vision succeed. That would be vain and somewhat selfish. He wants something else: to succeed at building wealth for his family. He takes no giant leaps. He risks not his whole wad. He proceeds, one step at a time, accelerating his failures until he has found a model that works.

He is not an opportunist. He merely uses opportunities to give him a lift.

DON'T TRY TO DO IT ON YOUR OWN

The successful family wealth business builder is not much like the popular vision of an entrepreneur. For another thing, he is not at all a “lone wolf.” He almost never succeeds on his own. A real business is a collaborative effort. It has to be. Businesses compete with other businesses. The one that relies on the talents, vision, ingenuity, and imagination of a single person is doomed to fail.

Our business is a collaboration of hundreds of people spread out all over the world. Its founder, the elder of your authors, explained its success at his 60th birthday party. His little discourse went something like this:

You see before you a man of modest talents, but immodest achievements. For the modesty of his talents, he has only himself to blame. But for the immodesty of his achievements, he has all the people in this room to thank.